



free will
and
determinism

A large, solid orange circle with a subtle drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle, the text "against compatibilist free will" is written in white, bold, lowercase letters, arranged in three lines.

**against
compatibilist
free will**

against
incompatibilist
free will

We can lay out this puzzle in terms of the following master argument against the reality of free will.

1. Free will is incompatible with determinism.
 2. If Libertarianism is true, then there is no free will.
-

C. There is no free will.

The master argument against the reality of free will

A compatibility believer in free will rejects premise (1). An incompatibilist believer in free will rejects premise (2).

Let's start with (2), which says that Compatibilism is false.

Now, so far we have been given no reason to think that either premise (2) or premise (3) is true. We're now going to look at two arguments — one for (2), and one for (3).

Compatibilist views of free will can be hard for some to get their minds around. How **could** I have free will if everything about me is, ultimately, determined by factors outside of my control?

It may help to sketch one story of compatibilist theory of free will to help you to see why the view should be taken seriously. What does it take for an action of yours to be free?

Consider the action of choosing a salad at the dining hall. Suppose that
you know that the following are all true:

You picked
the salad.

You wanted
to pick the
salad.

If you had
wanted to pick
something else,
you would have.

It seems reasonable to think that, if all of these things are true, then your
act of choosing the salad was free.

But it seems that all of these things are compatible with determinism
being true.

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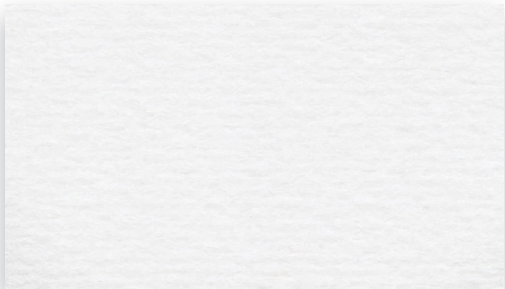
Consider the action of chopping a salad at the dining hall. Suppose that

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4. If determinism is true, the laws of



1. No one has any choice about events which

if P , then Q , then one has any choice

3. If determined, the only one

about whether @.

5. No one has any choice about what the laws

future is not distant with the state of the

6. If $\det A$ is true, then A has any

and none has any choice about whether,

2. None has any choice about DIDS. ATJR.

theorie about the fact that if DNR

~ If none has about choice about whether P,

nature say that if DINS ARE happy,

choice about DECISION (2, 6, 7)

then DECISION. (4,5)

happened in the distant past.

then DECISION happens. (3)

of interest.

C. If determinist is true, then no one has any

varlatatie + the last of the



choice about the laws of nature, then no

one has any choice about the past, no

choice principle, and determinism

rules out free will.

combination of four - that No

This argument seems to show that the

dearminism.

hence that free will is incompatible with

true, there are no free actions — and

seem quite plausible, the argument

Since the first three of these theses

seems to show that if determinism is



Real/|the master argument:

in free will, and find the consequent argument persuasive, it looks

The consequence argument is a defense of premise (1). If you believe

tempting to reply to the master argument by denying premise (2).

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